

Assignment 3: The Fixed Pie Fallacy and Why Good People Make Bad Decisions

Please reference the instructions in the Assignment 3 description on LEARN as well as the rubric while completing this assignment.

Part 1: Article reflection (400 to 600 words)

Select and read one of the articles provided in LEARN. Your reflective response should be 400-600 words and should use the DEAL model of reflection. When writing your reflective response, use the following questions to help guide your thinking:

1. Provide a citation for your source, with enough detail so the reader can easily identify it.

Hancock, A., & Georgiadis, P. (2021, December 3). *Travel industry cries foul over unstoppable rise of Google*. Financial Times. <https://www.ft.com/content/edc7f1b2-e114-4eeb-9902-3dd67f3d8f71>

2. **Describe** what is happening in your chosen article by providing a brief overview. Who is involved? What did they do or what happened? When and where did it happen?

The article "*Travel industry cries foul over unstoppable rise of Google*" (Hancock & Georgiadis, 2021) highlights growing concerns from travel companies like HomeToGo, Expedia, and Trivago over Google's dominance in online search. These firms argue that Google prioritizes its own travel products and paid ads, pushing competitors lower in search rankings unless they pay for visibility. This issue is especially pressing as the travel industry recovers from COVID-19 losses. Critics claim Google's practices harm competition and consumer choice. Meanwhile, regulators in the EU are exploring legal action through the proposed Digital Markets Act. Google defends its tools as user-friendly and claims they drive valuable traffic to partners. The conflict reflects broader concerns about big tech's market power.

3. **Examine** your chosen article by analyzing how it connects to your learning in this course. What connections did you make between your chosen article and what you learned in Unit 05 or Unit 06? How did the article change your thinking about what you learned in the course material? When referencing course materials, provide specific examples.

The article "*Travel industry cries foul over unstoppable rise of Google*" closely connects with the concept of the fixed-pie fallacy discussed in Unit 05. Many travel companies—including Expedia, HomeToGo, and Wizz Air—perceive Google's expansion into travel services as a zero-sum threat: that Google's gains come at their direct expense. This mindset mirrors fixed-

pie thinking, where success and opportunity are seen as finite, like slices of a pie. However, as we learned in the course, this fallacy often leads to unhealthy competition and missed opportunities for strategic cooperation.

Unit 05 emphasized that value can be created, not just distributed. Google's integration of travel tools arguably creates new value for users by streamlining the search and booking process, benefiting both consumers and some companies—especially smaller ones that might gain visibility through Google's platform. The article challenged my initial view that Google's dominance was purely harmful. Instead, it prompted me to reconsider how cooperation with dominant platforms might yield mutual benefits, rather than solely competing against them.

The case reflects how fixed-pie assumptions can lead to adversarial business relationships and even regulatory backlash, rather than collaborative innovation. It reinforces the importance of rethinking competition and embracing shared value creation in business strategy.

4. **Articulate your learning** by taking the perspective of a decision-maker (e.g., the travel industry, American society, etc.) in your chosen article. Would you make the same decisions outlined in the article, or would you act differently? Why? What aspects of that situation would you consider to help influence your ethical decision making? Or what variables would you wish you could control and why?

Taking the perspective of a travel industry decision-maker, I would likely act differently than simply criticizing Google's rise. While concerns about unfair competition and self-preferencing are valid, solely adopting an adversarial stance reflects fixed-pie thinking—believing Google's gains must come at our expense. Instead, I would look for strategic cooperation opportunities with Google to increase visibility and improve user experience, aligning with the mutual benefit principles from Unit 05.

Rather than resisting Google's tools, I'd consider how to optimize our listings on Google Travel or negotiate for better placement using data-driven performance metrics. I'd also advocate for transparency in Google's algorithm while still innovating within my own company to maintain a competitive edge.

Variables I'd want to control include the ranking algorithms and data access Google uses to display content, as these directly impact market visibility. Ultimately, a shift away from zero-sum thinking could open paths for innovation and shared success rather than conflict.

Part 2: Personal reflection (400 to 600 words)

Reflecting on content from Units 05 and 06 and your personal experience, respond to **one (1) of the two (2)** options below using the DEAL model of reflection. Highlight or bold your selected option.

- A. **Reflect on a situation where you have (or someone you know) witnessed unhealthy competition in school or the workplace. What made it unhealthy? What were the consequences?**
- B. Reflect on a personal experience where your values (or the values of someone you know) had a role in shaping your response to an incentive.

1. **Describe** your specific experience or situation. In depicting your example, please ensure you portray the people involved (including yourself, if involved) and their respective roles, the situation, and any additional information that would be helpful for the reader to understand your example.

In a third-year university course, my friend was paired with a group mate for a user experience project involving Figma. While my friend was proficient with the tools, her group mate lacked the technical skills and struggled to contribute. Initially, my friend tried to divide the work fairly and offer help, but as deadlines approached, she realized the quality of the final product would suffer if she didn't intervene. To protect their grade, she redid most of the project herself. Despite carrying the workload alone, both members received equal credit. This created stress and frustration, as her efforts went unrecognized while her group mate benefited unfairly. It highlighted the issue of unequal participation and accountability in group work.

2. **Examine** your example by connecting it to your learning from the course content. Using specific concept(s) discussed in Unit 05 or Unit 06, what led to the situation? How did/does this example reinforce (or challenge) your own morality or the morality of the person(s) described in your example? Reference specific course material where applicable.

This situation reflects key ideas from Unit 05, particularly the fixed-pie fallacy and the dangers of unhealthy competition. In theory, group work should be an opportunity for strategic cooperation, where each member contributes according to their strengths to achieve mutual success. However, my friend's experience shows how fixed-pie thinking can creep in when collaboration fails. Her group mate may have assumed that credit was guaranteed regardless of contribution—treating the grade as a fixed resource to claim, rather than something to earn collectively. This assumption discouraged active participation and undermined team dynamics.

This example challenged my own thinking about fairness and responsibility. While my friend acted ethically by safeguarding the group's outcome, she also internalized the cost—emotional stress and frustration—while her group mate avoided accountability. As discussed in the course, this dynamic illustrates how zero-sum assumptions and lack of communication

can lead to inefficiency and resentment, ultimately undermining the potential for genuine collaboration and growth.

3. **Articulate your learning** by sharing what you might do if you were presented with such a situation in the future. What factors might you consider to help influence your ethical decision making? What additional information might you need to make an informed decision?

If I were presented with a similar situation in the future, I would address the imbalance early by initiating open communication with my group member. I would clearly define roles and expectations from the start, ensuring that each person understands their responsibilities and has the support they need. If the issue persisted, I would document the contributions and, if necessary, inform the instructor to ensure accountability.

In making an ethical decision, I would consider factors such as fairness, the impact on my mental well-being, and the integrity of the academic process. I would ask myself: Is helping my group mate enabling growth, or simply allowing them to avoid responsibility? Additional information I might need includes university policies on group work and how instructors handle uneven contributions to guide my actions appropriately.